But Hinduism cannot be reduced to the *Bhagavad Gita*, or any single holy book. Dr Radhakrishnan put it best: to him, Hinduism is 'not a definite dogmatic creed, but a vast, complex, but subtly unified mass of spiritual thought and realisation.' The spiritual leader Dada Vaswani calls Hinduism variously 'a fellowship of faiths', 'a federation of philosophies', and 'a league of religions'. Note the plural in that last word.

Indeed, the writer Rutvij Merchant adapted a phrase of mine to make the point. I had written in my book, *India: From Midnight to the Millennium*, that any truism about India can be immediately contradicted by another truism about India. He observed that 'Hinduism appears to be very much like India; an essential paradox, as any attempt at a truism about Hinduism can be immediately contradicted by another truism about Hinduism.' Remarking that there are as many Hinduisms as there are adherents, he goes on to add: 'Interestingly, Shashi Tharoor's statement about India "that the singular thing about the country is that you can only speak about it in the plural", applies to Hinduism perfectly; if religion is seen as a technology that can be leveraged to grow spiritually and eventually achieve union with the Supreme, there appears to be no uniformity or synchronisation to the Hindu way; indeed the term "the Hindu way" is in itself a fallacy as there is no one Hindu way.'[10]

Merchant interestingly defines a Hindu as one who is an ardent seeker of Truth: 'An individual who strives to actively discern the existence of the objective Reality otherwise termed as God and attain Him if convinced of His existence, using means that are inherently subjective and dependent on the individual's own proclivities, beliefs and values, is a Hindu.' This definition of Hinduism, if it can be called that—since it could apply to almost anyone of any culture or religious faith—emphasises the individualist nature of the quest for truth, the role of reasoning in the process, and the ultimate yearning for God (whether one uses that term or speaks of the soul's merger with Brahman, the idea is the same).

Some Hindus reject the term 'Hindu' altogether as a description of their faith, preferring to speak of 'Brahmanism', though this is used by some Dalits and others as a term of abuse against the Brahmins who